



Students' Attitudes towards the Use of Mobile Applications in EFL Learning: The Case of Third Year EFL Learners at the Department of English, University of Amar Telidji.

Siham Hachani

*University Of Amar Telidji
Laghouat (Algeria)*

s.hachani@ens-lagh.dz

Maria Beyboumezrag

*Ecole Normale Supérieure de
Laghouat, (Algeria)*

m.beyboumezrag@ens-lagh.dz

Lamia Belferd

*Ecole Normale Supérieure de
Laghouat, (Algeria)*

l.belferd@ens-lagh.dz

Abstract

The present research aims to investigate EFL learners' attitudes towards mobile applications and their use in an EFL Algerian context. To achieve this purpose, a quantitative methodology was adopted to gather data about learners' attitudes and perceptions towards mobile applications in learning EFL at university. A questionnaire was administered to highlight learners' attitudes and familiarity with mobile apps and the obstacles they encountered while learning English. The participants were sixty-two (62) third year EFL students at the department of English, Amar Telidji University. Preliminary findings show positive attitudes and favorable considerations towards mobile learning applications use and an encouraging acceptability among EFL students, but also some hesitancy due to distractions. The results confirmed that most students consider mobile learning apps as favorable EFL technological learning tools. Moreover, gender differences significantly affect EFL learners' attitudes towards mobile apps use preferences.

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1. Introduction

Teaching/learning field nowadays witnesses a rapid expansion of online teaching and AI platforms along with a particular focus on mobile applications use in learning EFL. In Algeria however, EFL learners at the department of English in Amar Telidji university are still confused about the utility and benefit of this technological advancement in the field of EFL learning.

Recently, traditional technological devices such as desktop computers have been replaced with new and innovative digital devices such as mobile phones. As such, the most up-to-date educational systems, including schools and universities, employ the use of mobile devices in learning (Aldowah et al, 2019).

Technology is now an essential component of any modern educational system. It is used to provide learners with miscellaneous opportunities to access and acquire knowledge ; moreover, mobile technology has also become widely used in language learning (Hsu and Lin, 2021) as it provides learners with unlimited access to multiple learning resources and provide learners with opportunities to engage and collaborate with native speakers (Taj et al.,2016; Kukulsha-Hulme and Viberg, 2018).

1.2 Problem and Aim of the study

Mobile apps language learning use has transformed EFL pedagogy, yet learners' attitudes, particularly in understudied contexts like Algeria, remain questionable regarding its adoption, sustainability and acceptance. EFL students at the department of English in Amar Telidji university often receive traditional technological devices-based instruction. Desktop computers and data show tools are mostly adopted in teachers' lectures. EFL students use mobiles in a very restricted area. Recording lectures and checking pronunciation, grammatical and lexical items were the famous and most used operations for educational purposes. Yet, EFL students show both fear and willingness to discover other uses of mobile apps to prompt their own language learning. Furthermore, female EFL students favor instagram and snap chat mobile apps, while male learners prefer gamified-based mobile apps.

In this context, many students in higher education seek to identify mobile apps utility in EFL learning considering both genders' preferences, attitudes and perceptions. The latter may lead to insightful perspectives for future academic change at the department of English in Amar Telidji university.

This study aims to point out major EFL students' attitudes towards the use of mobile applications as learning tools. Drawing on the Technology Acceptance Model (Davis, 1989) and recent MALL researches (Kukulsh-Hulme, 2021), this study examines Algerian EFL learners' attitudes and perceptions towards mobile apps use through the following research questions:

1: What are the Algerian EFL students' attitudes towards mobile apps use in language learning?

2: Do Algerian EFL students' attitudes towards mobile apps use in learning vary by gender?

3: What are the most used learning mobile apps by EFL students?

As such, the following are the research hypotheses around which the study was conducted:

H1: Algerian EFL students generally exhibit positive attitudes towards using mobile apps in language learning.

H2: a/ There is a statistically significant difference in attitudes towards mobile apps use in EFL learning between Algerian male and female students.

b/ Female Algerian EFL students have more positive attitudes towards mobile learning apps compared to their male classmates.

H3: Algerian EFL students most frequently prefer vocabulary-based apps (quizlet) and gamified mobile apps. We hypothesize that EFL students hold positive attitudes towards mobile apps use along with female significant interest in particular mobile learning apps (Duolingo, Talk in) unlike male students who show different preferences.

2. Literature Review

Mobile apps language learning similarly means Mobile -Assisted Language Learning (MALL) refers to the use of mobile devices such as smart phones, tablets, and laptops, to facilitate language learning. Kukulsha-Hulme's (2012) early work defined MALL as "the use of smart phones and other mobile technologies in language learning, especially where portability and situated learning offer advantages".

The integration of mobile applications in language learning has made significant pedagogical transformations in the learning/teaching field. Since its emergence in the early 2000s, mobile apps learning has remarkably evolved due to technology advancements, transformations in educational pedagogy, and accessibility of mobile devices.

MALL is a subfield of the relatively new field of mobile learning, also referred to as

m-learning. Many researchers described m-learning as learning through mobile devices such as smart phones, PDAs, iPods, tablets, and all other devices having a 'mobility' aspect (Naismith, Sharples, Vavoula, and Lousdale 2004).

Kukulsh-Hulme & Shield (2008) described learning using mobiles as forms of education by means of handheld devices that are accessible anywhere and at anytime. The anywhere, anytime aspect distinguishes MALL from other electronic uses such as Computer-based Learning or computer-assisted language learning (CALL).

The study of mobile apps use in the classroom and language learning is not novel. Many research papers (Thornton & Houser 2005, Attewell 2004) have been conducted in this field supporting the use of mobile apps application in learning. All advocating the idea that mobile apps use in learning is a valuable teaching/learning method. Attewell (2004) for instance asserts that mobile phones have positively contributed in the field of learning in miscellaneous ways. As such, mobile apps use fosters learners' literacy and numeracy skills and considers their existing abilities. It can also encourage both independent and collaborative learning experiences along

with an emphasis on exteriorizing learners' areas of assistance and support.

In the same line of thought, Bluttner & Fiori (2009) investigated how social networking systems (SNSs) are used in a language course and the way learners responded to them. This study was primarily intended to examine the attitudes of language learners regarding the use of facebook (FB) in an academic setting.

Another interesting study held by Antir & Hamlaoui (2021) was an in depth comparison between Algerian EFL teachers' and learners' perspectives, policies, and challenges with implementing MALL. The study ended up with the conclusion that both teachers and learners positively outlined mobile apps integration in EFL learning. The data collected show that both teachers and students are conscious of the importance of mobile apps integration in learning, especially in modern EFL learning (Antir, Hamlaoui 2021). Nonetheless, only very few studies were conducted on examining students' attitudes and perceptions towards mobile apps use in EFL learning context (Chowdhury & Khaled 2024).

In this context, this research's purpose is primarily to shed light on the Algerian EFL students' attitudes towards mobile apps use in an Algerian EFL learning context.

Students' perceptions, preferences, acceptability and expectations are to be evolved while answering the questionnaire. The latter will serve as a data-base profile for teachers to account for their learners' learning interest and preferences.

3. Methods and Materials

This research employs a quantitative methodology. Bhangu et al. (2023) define quantitative research as a research methodology that involves the use of numerical data for data collection, interpretation, analysis and presentation of results.

Creswell (2014) asserts that quantitative research is 'an inquiry into an identified problem, based on testing a theory composed of variables, measured with numbers, and analyzed using statistical techniques'' (2014;p4).

A questionnaire was administered to gather data about EFL students' attitudes on the use of mobile apps in learning. The questionnaire was distributed to third year EFL students by the researcher herself (I was in charge of their teaching of Oral expression during the year 2024-2025) in an extra session and collected on the same day.

3.1 Participants

The population comprises all third year EFL students at the department of English. They are one hundred and thirty -five (135) students for the academic year 2024/2025. The sample that responded to the questionnaire was a group of sixty-two (62) students randomly selected. Their age ranged mostly between 19 and 23 years old.

Table 1. Students Age Distribution

<u>Age (years)</u>	<u>Number of students</u>
19	4
20	5
21	5
22	40
23	8
Total	62

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Age (years)	Number of students
19	4
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22	40
23	8
Total	62

The sample embodies male and female third year EFL participants.

Table 2. Students Gender Distribution

Female	40
Male	22
Total	62

3.2 Procedures

A questionnaire was administered to the sample to gather information about EFL students' attitudes towards mobile apps use. Data were collected through a questionnaire comprising closed and open-ended questions and general information section to exteriorize all possible information that will help in the analysis of data and the validation of the established hypotheses.

4. Results

Following the structure of the questionnaire, some questions are analyzed quantitatively as they were direct and

closed-ended. Whereas, open-ended ones need descriptive considerations.

Section one addresses general information or demographic data to elicit participants' age and gender, (Tables 1 and 2). Data show that forty (40) students were twenty-two (22) aged and the remaining participants ranged between 19 to 23 share nearly equal numbers. As for genre distribution, data reveal that females outnumber males. Further; gender influences the participants' responses in terms of mobile apps preference and frequency of use to a great extent.

Table 3. Smartphone Ownership among Students

Responses	Number of Students	Percentage
Yes	62	100%
No	0	0%
Total	62	100%

Table 4. Daily Smartphone Usage Among Students

Usage Frequency	Number of Students	Percentage
Not too much	2	3.2%
Sometimes	10	16.1%
Very often	30	48.4%
All the time	20	32.3%
Total	62	100%

Results reveal that 30 students among 62 use their mobiles very often daily; they form more than 48% of the research sample. Data indicate that 20 students

among 62 use their mobiles all the time which point out a close attachment to mobile apps and devices for multiple uses.

Table 5. Mobile Usage for Learning

Response	Number of Students
Yes	40
No	22
Total	62

Results indicate that forty (40) students use their mobiles for learning. This means that students tolerate the use of technology in learning and in particular mobile usage.

The remaining sample respondents do not use their mobiles for learning purposes.

Table 6. Students Usage of Mobile Learning Applications

Response	Number of Students
Yes	40
No	22
Total	62

Data reveal that more than half of the sample (40 students) use learning applications which point out a remarkable awareness of the utility of mobile apps to prompt their own learning. Surprisingly, 22 students do not use mobile apps in their learning; this matches the results of the previous question about mobile use in learning. This certainly emphasizes the accuracy and evidence of the data obtained. As question 6 contains an open-ended sub-question***If yes, name the most used one***, collected data show that Duolingo predominates students' most used mobile application with a number of 20 students while Oxford Dictionary covers 10 students use, and Merriam-Webster and ChatGPT come in last positions with 6 and 4 students use respectively. As such, the findings reveal that students are actually using their mobiles for learning purposes

regardless their interest or preferences. This prompted again the research questions and further confirmed the first research hypothesis H1 that Algerian EFL students generally exhibit positive attitudes towards using mobile apps in their learning experience.

The findings also revealed a great interest in Duolingo among female students with varying values regarding the use of Oxford Dictionary, Merriam-webstar, ChatGPT apps. All twenty (20) responses that selected Duolingo were females. This confirmed the research hypotheses H2 and H3; female Algerian EFL students have more positive attitudes towards mobile applications use, and EFL students most frequently prefer vocabulary-based and gamified apps with a significant female interest in Duolingo.

Table 7. Student's recommendations on mobile application use in EFL learning

Response	Frequency
Yes	60
No	2
Total	62

Results indicate that nearly all third year EFL students tolerated mobile apps usage to prompt their learning and they advise other students to use them. As such, data collected confirm the research hypothesis H1 that Algerian EFL students generally exhibit positive attitudes towards using mobile apps in language learning. However, female students have more positive attitudes compared to their male classmates (40 out of 62) and this confirmed the research hypothesis H2.

As for the sub-question why do you advise other students to use mobile apps in learning, data obtained revealed that nearly all third year EFL students encourage other learners to use mobile apps to enrich vocabulary, spelling and grammatical mistakes (Oxford Dictionary app.). Duolingo is the most used among students (females in particular) being considered as a means to get closer to native speakers of English since it offers authentic situations and intuitive interaction by which the

learner can correct, adjust and improve his language skills in a relaxed atmosphere.

The last question in the questionnaire was about the students attitudes towards mobile applications implementation in EFL Algerian university learning context. Most of them agree positively with the idea of incorporating digital tools to enhance EFL learning. Most students hold positive and promising attitudes towards mobile apps use to render their own learning more significant and effective in terms of quality and speed. However, they still doubt the accessibility, connectivity and fees issues of the internet.

5. Conclusion

Analyzing third year EFL students' attitudes towards mobile applications use denotes their awareness about the utility of integrating new technological devices to prompt their own learning. The research sample respondents show positive attitudes towards mobile applications along with a considerable doubt and uncertainty about

internet access, rapidity of Wi-Fi and applications fees. Students perceive mobile apps as useful means for specific learning tasks. Vocabulary acquisition emerged as a primary goal while spelling and grammatical accuracy hold a second targeted goal. The speaking skill was mostly tolerated by female students using the Duolingo application.

The present research is framed within the context of third year Algerian EFL students in Amar Telidji university, investigating their attitudes and perceptions towards the use of mobile apps in their own learning, denoting gender differences and language preferences. It provides nuanced perspectives on future considerations of mobile apps practices and policy at university level regarding age, gender and mobile applications preferences.

Future research should investigate the real implementation of mobile applications based learning in an EFL Algerian context accounting for three main variables: age, gender and language learning preferences. Further research should examine in depth the use of mobile apps at university considering internet connectivity issues, Wi-Fi accessibility and readiness of all staff members (teachers and students).

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